Q+A

Q. Has the feeling sunk in yet that you are a Candidates Champion and a World Chess Championship contender at 17?
After the result came out, I was just relieved and super happy. I've not yet fully realised the magnitude of this, but I'm very thrilled with how things went. And I'm looking forward to the World Championship.

Q. Before you went to Toronto, there was a special dinner that you, along with other players, attended at Viswanathan Anand's place. Did that help to get you into the right frame of mind for the Candidates?
Vishy Sir has been a huge support, and the meet was very enjoyable. We discussed a lot of things, had fun and even played some games. Vishy Sir shared some thoughts about his experiences at the Candidates. That really put me in good spirits.

Q. Before the tournament began, Magnus Carlsen had said he would be shocked if "Gukesh, Praggnanandhaa, Vidit or Abasov" win. Did that noise affect you?
I came to know about that a couple of days before the Candidates and, honestly, I didn't really care much about it. I think he gave an honest opinion and obviously, I was not one of the favourites. There were far more experienced players but deep down I always knew that if I managed to stay calm and focused, I had every chance to win.

Q. What was the moment when you felt you could clinch the Candidates?
Funnily, it was the seventh-round loss. I was obviously upset after the game, but after that, I had a rest day. When I woke up, I felt in my absolute best shape, full of energy and positivity. Maybe the painful loss gave me the extra energy and motivation I needed. I was fully fired up and thought if I just continued playing the right way, I had every chance of winning the tournament.

–with Siddharth Vishwanathan



Seventeen-year-old D. Gukesh has become the youngest player to win the Candidates chess tournament

Grand Young Master